By now, the news had spread in the TV industry that NDTV was poised to get the first Rahul interview. But as D-Day approached, Rahul's office suddenly changed their plan. The All India Congress Committee (AICC) session was on 17 January and Rahul's team felt that they'd rather wait till his big speech on the occasion before giving interviews. NDTV was promised that the interview would be done on the 18th, the day after the AICC session.

Arnab sensed an opening. He wrote a long mail to Rahul's office pointing out that Times Now's TRPs were much higher than NDTV's and of other competition in the English news space. 'We gave them charts with details of our viewership and even told them how in the US presidential elections, the first interview normally goes to the channel with the highest rating,' Arnab later told me. The TRP system in India is highly skewed and contentious. A few thousand television meters are expected to calculate viewership in a country with over a hundred million cable and satellite homes. But it was also the only available measurement to gauge a channel's or show's popularity.

Rahul's office bit the bait. The NDTV interview was again cancelled at the last minute, and Times Now was given the first interview, on 25 January. Arnab was met by Priyanka herself and Rahul's staff before the Congress leader walked in. It was meant to be a forty-five-minute interview. It lasted all of eighty minutes. 'Rahul did not ask for any questions in advance—he said he was ready to answer anything thrown at him,' says Arnab. Contrary to speculation, he claims neither Priyanka nor any other Congressman was actually present in the room during the recording. An M.F. Husain painting was the sole witness.

The interview was aired on the 27th night at 9 p.m. after incessant promos on the channel. When it began, Rahul appeared to show some flashes of promise, with a look of earnestness and well-meaning intent. By the end, it was clear to any viewer who was watching that Rahul was, in fact, completely out of his depth and had no clear answers or big idea or message. Arnab had come to the interview well prepared; Rahul, by